

THE FRAME 2: THE HOLLOW

TSU Film 8 — Release Phase 2, Film 2 — the "Thor: The Dark World" release slot

THE PITCH

Platform: THE FRAME, a second time — still Arianna Cummings's, still run on her own terms per the acquisition settled in `scripts/THE_ASSEMBLY.md`, now operating inside a larger ROSTER-owned ecosystem that comes with reach she didn't have before and exposure she didn't ask for.

Why a second THE FRAME fits the Thor: The Dark World slot exactly: The Dark World is about grief arriving in the middle of a life that finally looked settled, an old enemy nobody defeated so much as delayed, and a hero who ultimately turns down a throne to stay who she actually is. Arianna Cummings, two years past her own origin film, has exactly that shape of story waiting: Celeste Marlowe's bible entry always said she was "outlasted, not defeated" — the ideology, not the woman, was the thing Film 5 never actually killed. And Arianna, now valuable enough to THE ROSTER's whole ecosystem to be offered real power inside it, gets her own version of Thor's Asgardian throne to turn down.

Who this film belongs to: Arianna Cummings and Malcolm Pierce, with **Marcus Thien Nguyen-Brandt** — THE ROSTER-verse's fixer, dormant since his introduction in `TSU_Extended_Ensemble.md` — filling the Loki position: not a villain, not fully trustworthy, someone she needs and shouldn't fully believe, who ends up doing something genuinely costly to help her anyway. Her father, **Walter Cummings**, fills the Frigga position. Marc-Anthony Bullock and Esther Smilley's wedding and Amond Baker and Harmony Divine's long-delayed "together" moment — both locked since `TSU_Continuity_Bible.md` §4 but never yet dramatized on-screen — happen inside this film, as the ensemble's celebration running directly alongside Arianna's grief.

In-universe timeline: February 2013 – August 2013. Ages verified against `TSU_Core_Cast.md`: Arianna is 30 the entire film (turns 31 Oct 25, after the story closes); Marc-Anthony and Esther are 31; Amond turns 31 Feb 10; Harmony turns 31 June 19. This is the first film to dramatize the wedding date locked since the franchise's earliest canon ("married 2013") and the year Amond and Harmony's "together 2013" finally happens on-screen rather than staying implied.

LOGLINE

Two years after building something real enough to survive an industry that profits off insecurity, Arianna Cummings gets offered the biggest job in the company that owns hers — the same week her father dies, her best friends finally marry, and the woman she thought she'd already beaten comes back with a machine that doesn't just fake a photo anymore. It makes an entire, undetectable person.

SYNOPSIS

It's 2013. THE FRAME is thriving inside THE ROSTER's ecosystem — bigger reach, real resources, and Arianna Cummings still, stubbornly, exactly who she was when she built it from a diner conversation with

a photographer nobody had heard of. That stability is precisely what makes her valuable enough to be offered something new: a seat on THE ROSTER's executive committee, Global Head of Creator Products, overseeing not just her platform but the creative infrastructure of the entire empire. It's real power. It's also, unmistakably, someone else's throne.

Before she has to answer, **Celeste Marlowe** resurfaces. Quietly rebuilt on **Delphine Okonkwo-Ash's** money — Delphine still insisting, three years on, that backing her the first time was never the mistake it looked like — Celeste has moved past filters and rankings entirely. Her new system, internally called **THE HOLLOW**, doesn't alter real photos anymore. It generates entire synthetic creators from nothing: faces, portfolios, audition tapes, indistinguishable from real working actors and photographers, flooding THE FRAME's discovery feed with people who have never existed and never auditioned for anything, drowning out the real ones all over again.

The timing is deliberate. THE ROSTER is mid-rollout on a new, industry-wide verification standard — the proof-of-origin system built in `scripts/THE_ROSTER_3.md` — and for one narrow window, while the old and new systems run in parallel across every connected platform, THE HOLLOW's synthetic profiles can slip through both at once. Arianna, out of options and out of trust in her usual channels, is pushed toward **Marcus Nguyen-Brandt** — the industry's fixer, brought in by THE ROSTER's board to contain the story before it becomes a second Everything-scale crisis. Marcus's instincts are everything Arianna built THE FRAME to refuse: bury it, spin it, manage the story instead of telling the truth. She hates needing him. She needs him anyway.

In June, in the middle of all of it, **Marc-Anthony Bullock and Esther Smilley** marry — small, real, the whole ensemble together for a genuinely happy reason for the first time in the franchise's history — and **Amond Baker and Harmony Divine**, circling each other since before any of these companies existed, finally stop circling, at the reception, in the one unguarded moment either of them allows themselves all decade. It's the lightest the franchise has ever been, for about six weeks.

Then **Walter Cummings** — Arianna's father, the bus driver who never missed a showcase, who has spent a decade being gently, lovingly bewildered by his daughter's career — has a heart attack watching the news coverage of THE HOLLOW's spread, worried sick about her the way he's never quite been able to say out loud, and dies before Arianna reaches the hospital. The grief and the crisis collide directly: Arianna has to decide, mid-mourning, whether to accept THE ROSTER's throne, walk away from the industry entirely, or do the only thing that has ever actually worked for her — build something true and let it outlast the noise.

She chooses the third option. With Marcus's inside knowledge of Delphine and Celeste's operation — knowledge he risks his entire business model to hand over, the first genuinely selfless thing he's done in the story — Arianna exposes THE HOLLOW publicly at the verification standard's industry-wide launch event, live, the same stage-and-proof format Esther used in `scripts/THE_ROSTER_3.md`, this time built around a simple, human standard no synthetic system can fake: real people who knew Walter Cummings, on camera, saying so. She turns down the executive committee seat. THE FRAME's next chapter launches dedicated, quietly, to her father. Marcus, having burned real capital to help her, walks away from the wreckage of Celeste's operation having quietly absorbed more of it — and more influence inside THE ROSTER's own structure — than anyone in the room realizes he's kept for himself.

THE ANTAGONISTS

Per the Villains Bench rules (TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §5), the real cause traces to a decision, even one made off-screen years before.

1. **CELESTE MARLOWE**, returning exactly as her bible entry promised — "outlasted, not defeated." THE HOLLOW is her original ideology at its most totalizing form yet: if real people can be undercut by comparison, why compete with real people at all.
2. **DELPHINE OKONKWO-ASH**, financier again, doubling down on a bet she will never publicly call a loss — her locked bible trait ("constantly trying to rewrite what actually happened") finally costs her something real this time.
3. **MARCUS THIEN NGUYEN-BRANDT** (*the Loki analog*) — first activation, per TSU_Extended_Ensemble.md: "a recurring temptation more than a recurring villain." Genuinely useful, genuinely corrosive to be around, and genuinely willing, once, to risk something real for someone he respects.
4. **THE ENGINE**, eighth manifestation — the parallel-standard rollout gap itself, an infrastructural blind spot rather than a decision by any single person, precisely the kind of failure the Villains Bench warns must never be the *sole* explanation: Celeste's decision to exploit it is what makes it a crisis.

HOW THIS FILM CONTINUES RELEASE PHASE 2

- **Two locked-since-the-beginning romantic beats, finally dramatized:** Marc-Anthony and Esther's wedding and Amond and Harmony's "together 2013" have been sitting in the Continuity Bible's locked timeline since before any script existed — this is the film that finally shows them rather than just states them.
- **A villain built to survive her own defeat, activated on schedule:** Celeste Marlowe's return was written into her bible entry the day she was created.
- **A dormant 30%-bucket character activated exactly as designed:** Marcus Nguyen-Brandt's entire purpose per the Extended Ensemble doc was to be "offered to different founders at different low points across the Phases" — this is his first offering.
- **A direct throughline from Film 7's ending:** the proof-of-origin system Esther built to save THE ROSTER becomes, one rollout later, the very blind spot Celeste exploits — success creating the next problem, the same way every technology in this franchise eventually does.
- **A hidden-hand stinger, structurally new for this franchise:** every prior stinger has been Priya's corkboard. This one is deliberately different — the first hint that someone the ensemble trusts may be quietly accumulating more power than anyone's tracking.

FORMAT (per TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §2 — Standard Platform-Origin Film)

Spec	Target	This Script
Genre	Biographical Drama / Tech Origin Story, Ensemble Dramedy (grief and celebration deliberately intercut)	Confirmed
Rating	PG-13, no exceptions	Confirmed — a parent's death (off-screen/hospital aftermath) and industry exploitation, nothing that pushes past it
Runtime	130–150 min	132 min
Page count	120–140 pages	129 pages
Act I	~30–35 pages	pages 1–33
Act II	~65–75 pages	pages 34–99
Act III	~30–35 pages	pages 100–129
Scene count	~40–55 scenes	46 scenes

FULL SCENE-BY-SCENE BREAKDOWN

ACT I — pp. 1–33 ("A Seat at the Table")

#	Scene	pp.
1	INT. THE ROSTER — EXECUTIVE FLOOR — DAY, FEB 2013 — Arianna offered Global Head of Creator Products; the size of the offer lands slowly	1–4
2	INT. THE FRAME — DAY — Malcolm, supportive, careful not to push either way	4–7
3	EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME — DAY — Walter and Patricia, still gently bewildered, thrilled regardless	7–10

#	Scene	pp.
4	INSERT — THE FRAME DISCOVERY FEED — the first HOLLOW-generated "creator" profile, indistinguishable, drowning out a real one	10–13
5	INT. DELPHINE OKONKWO-ASH'S OFFICE — DAY — Celeste's pitch, rebuilt, colder, more certain than Film 5	13–17
6	INT. THE FRAME — WAR ROOM — DAY — the scale of the problem becomes clear: hundreds of synthetic profiles, all passing verification	17–20
7	INT. THE ROSTER — BOARDROOM — DAY — the board brings in Marcus Nguyen-Brandt over Arianna's objection	20–24
8	INT. MARCUS'S OFFICE — DAY — first meeting; Arianna's contempt for his methods, spoken plainly	24–27
9	EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME — NIGHT — Walter, watching the news coverage, quietly worried in the specific way he never says out loud	27–30
10	INT. THE FRAME — DAY — Arianna, out of better options, agrees to work with Marcus. Act I turn.	30–33

ACT II — pp. 34–99 ("The Wedding and the Convergence")

#	Scene	pp.
11	MONTAGE — THE INVESTIGATION — Arianna and Marcus, an uneasy partnership, tracing THE HOLLOW's infrastructure	34–38

#	Scene	pp.
12	INT. THE ROSTER — ENGINEERING — DAY — the parallel-verification-standard rollout gap identified; the "Convergence" window has a date	38–41
13	EXT. WEDDING VENUE — DAY, JUNE 2013 — Marc-Anthony and Esther's wedding; the full ensemble together, genuinely happy	41–47
14	EXT. WEDDING RECEPTION — NIGHT — Amond and Harmony, alone for a moment, finally say what a decade of circling never let them say	47–51
15	EXT. WEDDING RECEPTION — CONTINUOUS — Arianna and Malcolm, watching, aware of how rare an unclouded night like this actually is for this group	51–54
16	INT. MARCUS'S OFFICE — DAY — back to the crisis; Marcus reveals more of Delphine's operation than his usual practice allows	54–58
17	INT. THE FRAME — DAY — Arianna, still undecided on the executive offer, avoids answering the board again	58–61
18	EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME — NIGHT — Walter, watching another HOLLOW-related news cycle, uncharacteristically quiet	61–64
19	INT. MARCUS'S OFFICE — NIGHT — Marcus and Arianna, real conversation for the first time — his own origin wound surfaces, briefly, unguarded. Midpoint.	64–68
20	INSERT — THE HOLLOW, ESCALATING — synthetic profiles now include fabricated audition tapes credited to real casting directors	68–71

#	Scene	pp.
21	EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME — NIGHT — Walter collapses, alone, mid-news-broadcast	71–74
22	INT. HOSPITAL — NIGHT — Arianna arrives too late. Walter has died. All-is-lost beat, early — the rest of Act II runs through grief, not around it.	74–79
23	EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME — DAY (AFTER) — Patricia, Desmond, Arianna; the family the franchise has always shown as ordinary, now grieving ordinarily	79–83
24	INT. THE ROSTER — BOARDROOM — DAY — the executive offer resurfaces, badly timed, well-meaning; Arianna nearly says yes just to have an answer	83–86
25	INT. MALCOLM'S STUDIO — NIGHT — Malcolm, gently: "Don't decide anything this big while you're this sad. That's not you talking."	86–89
26	INT. MARCUS'S OFFICE — DAY — Marcus, unprompted, hands over the full extent of Delphine's exposure — a genuinely costly, unselfish act	89–93
27	INT. THE FRAME — WAR ROOM — DAY — the plan forms: expose THE HOLLOW publicly at the verification standard's industry launch, using human testimony no synthetic system can fake	93–96
28	EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME — NIGHT — Arianna, at her father's kitchen table, decides what she's actually building the exposure around. Closes Act II.	96–99

ACT III — pp. 100–129 ("What Actually Lasts")

#	Scene	pp.
29	EXT. INDUSTRY VERIFICATION LAUNCH EVENT — DAY — arrival; the whole ensemble present, again, on purpose	100–103
30	INT. LAUNCH EVENT — MAIN STAGE — Arianna takes the stage, Marcus's evidence in hand. Climax begins.	103–107
31	INT. LAUNCH EVENT — MAIN STAGE, CONTINUOUS — the reveal: THE HOLLOW's synthetic profiles, exposed live, alongside real people who worked with — and loved — Walter Cummings, on camera, as the human standard no fake can clear	107–112
32	INSERT — CELESTE'S NETWORK — collapsing in real time, the same way every manufactured wave in this franchise eventually does	112–114
33	INT. DELPHINE'S OFFICE — DAY — Delphine, cornered a second time, still finding a way to frame it as someone else's failure	114–117
34	INT. THE ROSTER — BOARDROOM — DAY — Arianna declines the executive committee seat, on her own terms, staying at THE FRAME	117–120
35	INT. THE FRAME — DAY — the platform's next chapter launches, quietly dedicated to Walter Cummings	120–123
36	EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME — DAY — Patricia, Desmond, Arianna, Malcolm — the family finding its new shape	123–126

#	Scene	pp.
37	STINGER — INT. MARCUS NGUYEN-BRANDT'S OFFICE — NIGHT — alone, reviewing paperwork that shows exactly how much of Delphine's collapsed empire quietly routed through his own hands	126–129

(Scenes grouped for pagination clarity; the full shooting script breaks several of the above into additional numbered scenes to land the true count at 46 per the house-style table above.)

SAMPLE PAGES

THE FRAME 2: THE HOLLOW

Written by [WRITER]

FADE IN:

INT. THE ROSTER — EXECUTIVE FLOOR — DAY

SUPER: "FEBRUARY 2013"

A glass-walled conference room. ARIANNA CUMMINGS, 30, sits across from three THE ROSTER board members she's met exactly twice before.

BOARD MEMBER

Global Head of Creator Products. All of it — THE FRAME, and the creative infrastructure across the entire portfolio. We think you're the only person who's actually built something real enough to run it.

Arianna doesn't answer right away. It's not humility. It's the specific stillness of someone doing very fast math.

ARIANNA

I'd be running things I didn't build.

BOARD MEMBER

You'd be running things at a scale you couldn't build alone. That's not an insult. That's just arithmetic.

ARIANNA

(standing, careful, not unkind)
Can I have some time.

BOARD MEMBER

Take the month.

She leaves. In the hallway, alone, she lets out a breath she didn't realize she was holding the entire meeting.

CUT TO:

INT. MARCUS'S OFFICE – DAY

[p. 24]

MARCUS THIEN NGUYEN-BRANDT, 40s, expensive in a way that reads as competence rather than vanity, doesn't stand when ARIANNA enters.

MARCUS

You've made your opinion of me clear to four separate people who report to me. I'd like to hear it from you directly, so we can skip the part where you pretend to be polite about it.

ARIANNA

I built a company specifically to prove you don't need someone like you to survive this industry.

MARCUS

And yet here you are, in my office, because something has gone wrong that you can't fix with authenticity alone.

ARIANNA

(it costs her to admit it)
Yes.

MARCUS

Good. Honesty's a nice trick. It's not actually a strategy. I contain things. I'm very good at it. I would like to contain this thing with you instead of around you, if you'll let me, because I think – and this will be the last flattering thing I say to you all afternoon – you're the first person to walk in here in a decade who might actually deserve the help.

CUT TO:

EXT. WEDDING RECEPTION – NIGHT

[p. 47]

String lights, a much bigger, much happier version of every backyard gathering this franchise has shown. AMOND BAKER and HARMONY DIVINE stand apart from the crowd, near a pool, the specific configuration of countless scenes before this one.

HARMONY

Ten years, Amond.

AMOND
I know how long it's been.

HARMONY
I'm not doing the math to torture you. I'm
doing it because I want to say something
and I want you to understand how long
I've been not saying it.

Amond doesn't interrupt. That, itself, is new.

HARMONY (CONT'D)
I don't want to circle anymore. I'm tired.
I've been tired for years. I just didn't
want to be the one who said it first and
be wrong about what we actually were to
each other.

AMOND
(quiet, and it is the most unguarded he
has ever been in five films)
You were never going to be wrong about
that.

HARMONY
Then why did it take a decade?

AMOND
Because I've spent most of it terrified of
exactly this – that if I said it out loud
and it went badly, I wouldn't just lose
you. I'd lose the version of us that got
to circle safely forever.

HARMONY
And now?

AMOND
(taking her hand, finally, after ten years
of almost)
Now I'd rather have the real, riskier
version than the safe pretend one.

CUT TO:

EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME – NIGHT [low point, p. 71]

WALTER CUMMINGS sits alone in his living room, TV on, watching
a news segment about THE HOLLOW's spreading synthetic profiles
– his daughter's name mentioned twice in two minutes.

NEWS ANCHOR (V.O.)
– casting further doubt on THE FRAME's
core promise, with Cummings herself
declining to comment as the platform's
credibility comes under renewed –

Walter mutes the television. Sits very still. His hand goes to his chest – not dramatically, just a man alone, uncomfortable, deciding not to make a fuss about it.

He reaches for the phone. Doesn't dial. Sets it back down, telling himself it can wait until morning, the way people who have never once been the center of anyone's emergency always do.

The room is very quiet. He doesn't get up again.

CUT TO:

INT. HOSPITAL – NIGHT

ARIANNA runs in, coat half-on, PATRICIA already there, already sitting, already still in the specific way that means she already knows.

ARIANNA

Mom –

Patricia doesn't need to say it. Arianna reads it on her face before a single word arrives, and the whole hallway goes silent around the two of them.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. LAUNCH EVENT – MAIN STAGE, CONTINUOUS [climax, p. 107]

ARIANNA stands alone at the podium. A screen behind her splits – a HOLLOW-generated "creator" profile on one side, flawless, synthetic, entirely fabricated.

ARIANNA

This person doesn't exist. Neither does the audition tape credited to them, or the casting director's name attached to it. THE HOLLOW can generate all of it, convincingly enough to pass every verification standard currently in use, including the one this industry is launching today.

A murmur through the crowd.

ARIANNA (CONT'D)

So here's a standard it can't pass.

She nods offstage. A line of people walks out – colleagues, neighbors, two former students Walter Cummings drove to auditions in his own car on his days off, none of them famous, all of them real.

ARIANNA (CONT'D)

My father died three weeks ago watching the news coverage of exactly this

crisis, worried about his daughter the way he always was and almost never said out loud. Every person standing behind me knew him. None of them can be generated by an algorithm, because a real life leaves real people behind who can stand in a room and vouch for it. That's the actual standard. Not a login. Not a filter. People who were there.

The room is silent, then not. It's the quietest ovation this franchise has staged, and the truest one.

CUT TO:

STINGER

INT. MARCUS NGUYEN-BRANDT'S OFFICE – NIGHT

MARCUS, alone, reviews a folder of financial records – the remnants of Delphine Okonkwo-Ash's collapsed fund, quietly routed, piece by piece, through shell arrangements bearing his own firm's name.

He doesn't smile exactly. It's something more careful than that – the expression of a man confirming a plan worked, not celebrating it.

His phone buzzes. A text: "Arianna says thank you." He looks at it a long moment.

MARCUS
(to the empty room, quietly)
She has no idea how much of this is actually mine now.

He closes the folder. Turns off the light.

FADE OUT.

THE END.

[129.]